

# Cat Poop Refuses Litter Box — Action Checklist

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## OBSERVE YOUR CAT AT HOME

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- ☐ **Observe Your Cat at Home:** Keep a 3-day poop journal documenting times, locations, stool consistency on a 1-5 scale, and straining behavior to identify patterns before your vet appointment.
- ☐ **Observe Your Cat at Home:** Check the litter box daily for hard, dry, small stools that look like rabbit pellets, which indicate constipation is making defecation painful for your cat.
- ☐ **Observe Your Cat at Home:** Watch your cat's posture in the litter box for straining, crying, or quick exits without producing anything, and note how often this happens.
- ☐ **Observe Your Cat at Home:** Feel your cat's belly for hardness or distension, which signals constipation or digestive blockage requiring veterinary attention.

## WATCH FOR MEDICAL WARNING SIGNS

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- ☐ **Watch for Medical Warning Signs:** Monitor for vomiting after eating, weight loss over weeks, dull coat, and lethargy that may indicate IBD or chronic digestive disease.
- ☐ **Watch for Medical Warning Signs:** Watch for fewer bowel movements than normal, which means less than 1-2 stools per day, indicating your cat is holding it due to pain.
- ☐ **Watch for Medical Warning Signs:** Be aware that your cat may have diarrhea mixed with constipation, which is a classic sign of inflammatory bowel disease affecting digestion.
- ☐ **Watch for Medical Warning Signs:** If your cat hasn't pooped in 48 or more hours, seek immediate veterinary attention because a blockage can be life-threatening.

## PREPARE FOR THE VET VISIT

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- ☐ **Prepare for the Vet Visit:** Bring your 3-day poop journal, photos of stools showing normal versus hard and dry samples, and a complete list of all food and treats with brands.
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- ☐ **Prepare for the Vet Visit:** Document your litter box setup including number of boxes, litter type, box dimensions, and locations so your vet can assess whether the setup may be contributing to the problem.

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  - ☐ **Prepare for the Vet Visit:** Ask your vet to run a thorough workup including physical exam, blood panel, fecal test, urinalysis, and abdominal ultrasound to rule out medical causes.

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  - ☐ **Prepare for the Vet Visit:** If your vet says the problem is behavioral without running tests, ask for them specifically or get a second opinion because medical causes should always be ruled out first.
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